HAWK

FINANCIAL CRIME OPERATIONS

Where an AML alert actually goes

One alert. A dozen systems.
A walk through what your analysts really do.

Swipe →

A rule triggers at 09:14.

A transaction crosses a threshold. The alert lands in a queue with forty others. Nothing about it says whether it matters.

01 **Internal playbook**
The procedure that says what to check, in what order, and what evidence to keep

The first thing an analyst opens isn't the customer record. It's the document telling them what they're required to do.

WHO IS THIS?

Three systems before a single question is answered.

02 **Core banking**
Account history, balances, related accounts

03 **Customer profile**
Stated occupation, expected activity, risk rating

04 **KYC records**
Onboarding documents, last review date, gaps

Three logins. Three interfaces. Nothing joins them.

Now leave the bank entirely.

05 **Sanctions & watchlists**
Name matching, and the false positives that come with it

06 **PEP screening**
Political exposure, associates, family

07 **Adverse media**
Search, read, discount, repeat

08 **Company registry**
Ownership, directorships, shell indicators

Four more sources. Most of them opened in a browser tab.

The institutional memory problem.

09 **Case management**
Prior alerts on this customer, and how they were closed

10 **Case archive**
Anything older than the retention window on the live system

The analyst who closed the last three alerts on this customer left in March. Their reasoning lives in a free-text field.

Two more systems, and the clock is running.

11 **Workflow / task management**
Escalation path, approvals, SLA tracking

12 **Regulatory reporting**
If it escalates, the whole story is retyped in a new format

Everything gathered so far now has to be reassembled into a narrative someone else can defend.

12

systems touched to reach one decision, on one alert, out of a queue of forty.

Every switch is a context switch. Every context switch is a chance to lose the thread — and the reason the same alert takes forty minutes on Monday and twelve on Thursday.

The other side isn't working this way.

Financial crime has industrialised. Laundering is sold as a service, priced and scaled.

Their cost per attempt is falling. Your cost per investigation has not moved in a decade.

That gap is not something you can hire your way out of.

The systems aren't the problem.

Nobody being responsible for the space between them is.

How many does your team touch before a case is closed?

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